



THE FIRST WORLD WAR ADVENTURES OF NARIMAN KARKARIA
by Nariman Karkaria; translated by Murali Ranganathan
HARPER COLLINS INDIA
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THE RAJ NEEDED THE SACRIFICE BY COLONIAL SOLDIERS, BUT WAS UNWILLING TO GRANT A COMMISSION TO A DESI OFFICER WHO MIGHT GIVE ORDERS TO A WHITE MAN

BOOKS

GREAT DESIS OF THE GREAT WAR

Rather than join Indian units, Hardit Singh Malik and Nariman Karkaria both fought World War I alongside white soldiers. Two new books detail their grit and successes

In an odd refraction of historiography, recountings of the First World War, especially the stories of Indian soldiers are only now cutting through the massive curtain of material about the Second World War. *For King and Another Country* by Shrabani Basu was an eye-opener about the long obscured million-strong desi participation that basically saved the skin of Britain and France in the conflict. While Basu's book concentrates on the testimonies of ordinary foot-soldiers, the books under review here reveal the stories of two complete outliers, Hardit Singh Malik and Nariman Karkaria.

The two young men have a few things in common: first, neither of them was from the peasant class that made up the desi regiments; second, neither of them really needed to join up yet both strove to do so; third, neither of them joined a desi unit, both finding their way to serve alongside *gora* combatants.

The differences are also equally sharp. Malik comes from a well-to-do Sikh family of Rawalpindi; as a complete *adarsh balak*, he does well at studies and sports and is sent to boarding school in England. He gets into Oxford, after which a secure future awaits him; instead, he joins first the French Red Cross and then the RFC, the precursor of the RAF. Karkaria, on the other hand, seems to be a Huckleberry Finn in a *sadra*. At the age of 16, he runs away from home in Navsari and makes his way to Bombay, Hong Kong and Peking; he returns briefly and takes off again, to China, Tsarist Russia and